

Bushwhacking

I resent this immensely. Nonetheless I persist.

Progress southeast has been slow. These lands are fully uncivilized, choked with underbrush and detritus, only spanned by fickle and labyrinthine game trails. While I may be no tracker, calling in a few favors from friends on the other side of the Gate has kept me on course. This is an extreme measure, however, the nearer I get the more this choking wilderness seems to interfere with my summons. I find myself still having to clear out sections of brush by hand, warding my camp each night against whatever nocturnal threats prowl confidently through this, their ancestral homes. Wolves are no threat to me, but once something invisibly tested my perimeter, by the time I roused I only glimpsed a pair of glowing blue slits vanish into the treeline. At least Frankie is good company.

Luckily, unluckily?, finding water has been no issue. I have been following a spring-fed cataract that I believe spills into a tributary of the mighty Heleguin (or at least that's what the Neth'tel call it, the local name escapes me). The water tastes clear and fresh, old in the best way. When you submerge you can hear the song of the earth.

The terrain is growing stranger. Upturned rocks have pale veins of some undiscovered mineral. The trees are starting to reflect more moonlight than they ought to. Once, at dawn, between two blue ridges I took my first glimpse with my real, physical, eyes at this silvered latticework described by my master, momentary and fleeting.

I am sore. I am bitten. My spells are spent on logistics instead of insight. And yet, I feel close. I feel the same pressure from my astrolabe sighting. I feel the same excitement and fear at the unknown. I will take a day to rest before proceeding but discovery is nigh.